Contextual interview protocol checklist

The interview protocol is the script used by the interviewer. Use this checklist to prepare your interview protocol.

Section	What to say or ask	Tips and examples
1. Introduction	☐ Introduce yourself.	Your name and one sentence about yourself.
	☐ Introduce other team members present at the session and why they are there.	
	☐ Explain the goals of the interview session.	
	☐ Explain what will happen during the session: what kinds of questions you will ask, what you will ask them to do, and that you will ask them to show you their environment, objects/products they use, and what they do with them.	This helps the participant know what to expect.
	☐ Tell the participant how long the session will take.	
	☐ Obtain informed consent.	Make sure the participant signs the form or says “I agree” before you get started. Start the recording only after you obtain consent.
2. Demographics & overview	☐ Interviewee’s name.	
	☐ Age / gender / race, ethnicity, or country / occupation	
	☐ Other demographic questions that are relevant to the topic of the interview.	For example, if the interview is about athletes’ nutrition: “What is your sport?” “In what capacity and form do you practice it?”
3. Questions about the topic	☐ Tell the participant that you will now ask questions about the topic of the interview.	

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	☐ Ask the participant to tell you 1-2 specific stories that relate to events and/or activities about the topic of the interview.	For example, if the interview is about athletes' nutrition: 1. Tell me about your practice/training session yesterday. Follow ups: When was it? Where? How long? What was it like? What did you do? How did you feel? 2. Tell me about all the meals you had yesterday. Follow ups: What did you eat for breakfast? Lunch? Dinner? Snacks during the day? When was each meal? Where? Why did you eat each specific food? Who prepared each meal? The events/activities need to relate to specific times & locations. For example, instead of asking "What do you eat for breakfast?", ask "What did you have for breakfast today?"
	☐ For each story, ask "tell me more about that", to get more details.	Asking for more details will provide you an in-depth understanding of their activities, behaviors, and contexts. If the participant doesn't voluntarily add the details, ask specifically about when, where, with whom, and how everything happened in the story.
	☐ For each story, ask "why" follow up questions.	Asking "why" several times will help you go beyond surface level goals to deeper values that underlie the stories and motivate the participant to achieve their goals.
	☐ For each story, ask "how did it make you feel", and remember to ask "why" after that.	Asking about emotional responses will provide you with details about successes, failures, problems, and frustrations in the participant's life as they relate to the topic.
	☐ For each story, ask about imagined alternatives they could hope or wish for.	Asking the participant to imagine alternative ways the story could have gone or ended could give you a glimpse into their values and needs. For example: "If you could have anything for breakfast this morning, what would it be? How would it be made? Who would make it? Why would you want it?"

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	☐ Ask the participant if this is a representative/typical story. If not, ask them why it's not typical and ask them to tell you about an event/activity that is representative.	"So, today you skipped breakfast because you didn't have time, but typically you have breakfast. Can you tell me about the last time you had breakfast? When was it?" (then repeat all the follow-ups)
	☐ After all the stories are told, ask about hopes and wishes for the future as they relate to the topic.	Wrapping up the stories with broad future-oriented questions provides you with big picture goals, values, and challenges the participant is facing.
4. Products and show & tell	☐ Tell the participant that you will now ask them to show you things they use that relate to the topic of the interview.	
	☐ Ask the participant to show you objects, products, or tools (physical / digital) that they use in the activities that relate to the topic of the interview.	For example, for the athlete nutrition study, ask them to show you their fridge and kitchen cabinets with the foods they eat. Also ask them what tools they use to get and prepare foods (physical setup of their kitchen, grocery lists/apps, recipes) and any tools they use, if any, to plan or keep track of their nutrition.
	☐ For each product/tool, ask about the last time they interacted with it, the frequency they use it, what they used it for, and why.	Try to get specific stories, instead of general ways in which they interact with the product. Make it specific in time & location.
	☐ For each product/tool, ask the participant to show you how they use it.	Refer specifically to the last time they used the product, and ask them to walk you through the interaction and explain each step.
	☐ For each product/tool, ask the participant to explain and reason how and why they do things in a certain way.	Refer specifically to the last time they used the product.
	☐ For each product/tool, ask about its positive sides.	Potential questions: "How does [this product] help you achieve your goal?" "How is [this product] helpful to you?" "What do you like about [this product]?"

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	☐ For each product/tool, ask about its negative sides.	Potential questions: “What do you dislike about [this product]?” “Where does [this product] fall short?” “What are some limitations of [this product]?” “What are some concerns you have about [this product]?” “What would you change about [this product]?”
5. Tour	☐ Ask the participant to give you a tour of the space in which the interview takes place.	The interview should be in the participant’s environment: home, office, car, or other place that is relevant to the interview topic. For example, in the athlete nutrition study, tour their kitchen (open the fridge and cabinets!), dining halls they go to, or the athletic facilities where they train.
	☐ If at the tour you observe products/tools that the participant did not mention earlier, repeat the questions above about products/tools.	Use the tour to probe further and deeper into the participant’s goals, motivations, activities, products, and emotional responses.
6. Closure	☐ Ask the participant if they have any questions for you.	
	☐ Explain what you will do with the results.	
	☐ Thank the participant for their participation.	
	☐ Offer a small gift.	

General protocol notes

1. In each section, start with easy questions and gradually increase the complexity of the questions, to help you dive deep into the topic.
2. Maintain *flexibility*:
   - If the participant is *talkative*, skip some questions to fit the time limit.
     Plan ahead by marking questions that are less crucial that you could skip.
   - If the participant is *quiet or shy*, you will need to ask more questions to get the information out of them.
     Plan ahead by preparing potential follow-up questions, specifically, “why” and “how.”
3. Be ready to *improvise* as needed based on circumstances out of your control.